

Survivorship Bias

What is it?

Focusing on the successes you see while ignoring the failures you don't.

People often draw conclusions from the “survivors” of a process and forget those who didn't make it — creating a false sense of success.

For example, you might admire successful entrepreneurs like Elon Musk or Steve Jobs but overlook the thousands who tried similar ideas and failed.

History

The concept became widely known during **World War II**, when statistician **Abraham Wald** studied damaged aircraft returning from missions.

Military engineers wanted to reinforce the areas hit most often, but Wald realized the data ignored planes that *didn't* return — those hits were likely fatal.

His insight saved countless lives and became one of the earliest examples of **survivorship bias** in action.

The Psychology Behind It

Humans are naturally drawn to success stories because they're inspiring and visible. Failures, on the other hand, are hidden or forgotten.

This creates distorted perceptions — in UX, that means relying too much on positive feedback while ignoring drop-offs, uninstalls, or silent churn.

Why It Matters

- Produces misleading conclusions
- Masks user pain points and weak spots
- Overestimates success and usability
- Leads to poor design or business decisions
- Distorts product analytics and growth strategy

How to Apply It

- **Study failures** – Eg: Analyze exit surveys, churn data, and crash logs.
- **Use diverse feedback** – Eg: Combine analytics with interviews and social data.
- **Validate assumptions** – Eg: Cross-check data sources and run peer reviews.
- **Encourage transparency** – Eg: Discuss lessons learned from failed features.
- **Balance narratives** – Eg: Highlight both success stories and learnings from setbacks.

Theory in Action

- **Microsoft** openly analyzed learnings from the failure of **Windows Phone**, helping them refine future product strategies.
- **Unilever's Open Innovation platform** invites real user feedback — including failed ideas — to guide continuous product improvement.

Final Thought

Success tells only half the story.

Designers and businesses that also study what *didn't* work gain a complete picture — one that leads to smarter, more inclusive, and resilient products.